DETECTION THREAT LANDSCAPE

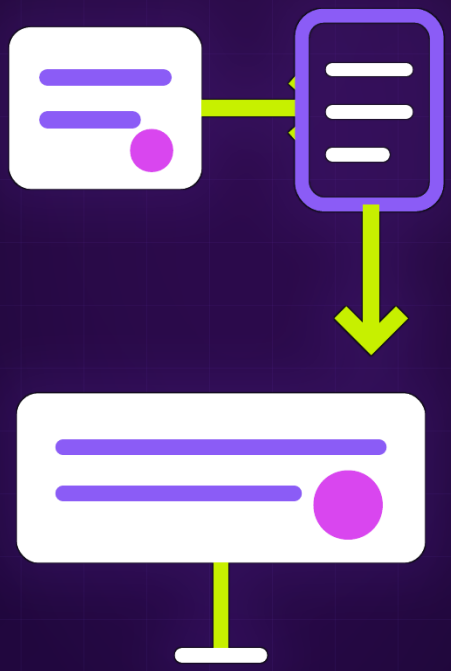
WSCRIPT · VBS · POWERSHELL · PS1

APEX ACCELERATOR WSCRIPT TO POWERSHELL

Defender XDR hunt for the REF8801 Windows bootstrap chain in which WScript launches PowerShell against campaign-named scripts staged in the user Temp directory.

HUNTING QUERY

CONFIDENCE: MEDIUM



REPORT DATE
14 October 2026

STATUS
Untested implementation sketch

PRIMARY PLATFORM
Microsoft Defender XDR

OPERATIONAL VALUE
8.0 / 10

CONTROLLED EIGHT-PAGE THREAT DOSSIER

EXECUTIVE ASSESSMENT

Decision, confidence and evidence boundary.

ASSESSMENT

OPERATIONAL VALUE

8.0

Direct process telemetry can capture a source-observed WScript-to-PowerShell bridge plus two exact campaign script pairs.

CLASSIFICATION

Hunting query

Medium confidence. The execution behavior is direct, while the filenames remain mutable campaign artifacts.

1primary table
6direct filters
0thresholds
0joins

Evidence boundary

A match does not prove malicious npm execution, payload retrieval, malware execution, persistence, credential access, C2, compromise, or REF8801 attribution.

BEHAVIOR AND EVIDENCE

Observed facts separated from interpretation and inference.

MECHANICS

Class	Evidence
Source fact	Elastic observed two malicious npm launchers selecting Windows commands after a POST to attacker infrastructure.
Source fact	The CLI package wrote _apex_run.ps1 and _apex_run.vbs; the audit package wrote _audit_run.ps1 and _audit_run.vbs under %TEMP%.
Source fact	The VBS wrapper used WScript.Shell.Run to start PowerShell with -NoProfile -ExecutionPolicy Bypass -File, and the bootstrap launched wscript.exe with the VBS file.
Vendor interpretation	The packages were malicious from publication rather than compromised legitimate packages.
Analyst inference	A direct parent-child process event should retain both the PowerShell and initiating WScript command lines.

Detection hypothesis

If an attacker executes the observed Windows bootstrap, endpoint telemetry should show wscript.exe launching powershell.exe with the published flags and paired Temp script names. The chain can be distinguished through exact script pairing, wrapper collection, npm provenance, signer and package-owner context.

ATT&CK: T1059.005 Visual Basic · T1059.001 PowerShell

TELEMETRY CONTRACT

Minimum data contract and observability limits.

TELEMETRY

REQUIRED

DeviceProcessEvents

Microsoft Defender for Endpoint process creation with created-process and initiating-process command lines.

OPTIONAL ENRICHMENT

DeviceFileEvents, npm installation evidence, package-lock provenance, file signer/hash, network events, and approved developer tooling inventory.

Field	Reliability	Purpose
Timestamp, DeviceId, DeviceName	Documented	Scope and pivots
FileName, FolderPath	Documented	PowerShell child
ProcessCommandLine	Documented	Flags and PS1 artifact
InitiatingProcessFileName	Documented	WScript parent
InitiatingProcessCommandLine	Documented	VBS artifact
AccountName, SHA1, ReportId	Documented	Triage and event identity

Coverage failure

No Defender for Endpoint, missing command lines, renamed interpreters, altered script names, in-memory execution, or activity outside retention.

PRIMARY KQL

Direct source-supported conditions with investigable output.

HUNTING

STATUS

Hunting query - Untested implementation sketch

KQL — UNTESTED

```
// REF8801 / Apex Accelerator - WScript launches PowerShell from campaign-named Temp scripts
// Platform: Microsoft Defender XDR Advanced Hunting
// Status: Hunting query - Untested implementation sketch
// Confidence: Medium
// Classification: Campaign-specific artifact with direct parent-child execution behavior
// Required telemetry: Microsoft Defender for Endpoint DeviceProcessEvents
// Evidence: Elastic observed wscript.exe launching a VBS wrapper that starts PowerShell
// with -NoProfile -ExecutionPolicy Bypass -File against _apex_run.ps1 or _audit_run.ps1.
// This hunt does not prove npm execution, successful payload download, malware execution,
// persistence, credential access, C2, compromise, or REF8801 attribution.
DeviceProcessEvents
| where FileName =~ "powershell.exe"
| where InitiatingProcessFileName =~ "wscript.exe"
| where ProcessCommandLine contains "-NoProfile"
    and ProcessCommandLine contains "-ExecutionPolicy"
    and ProcessCommandLine contains "Bypass"
    and ProcessCommandLine contains "-File"
| where ProcessCommandLine contains "_apex_run.ps1"
    or ProcessCommandLine contains "_audit_run.ps1"
| where InitiatingProcessCommandLine contains "_apex_run.vbs"
    or InitiatingProcessCommandLine contains "_audit_run.vbs"
| project Timestamp, DeviceId, DeviceName, AccountName,
          FileName, FolderPath, ProcessCommandLine, SHA1,
          InitiatingProcessFileName, InitiatingProcessFolderPath,
          InitiatingProcessCommandLine, ReportId
| order by Timestamp desc
```

TRIAGE AND TUNING

Turn the parent-child event into attributable evidence.

WORKFLOW

1

Preserve

Retain the raw process event, full command lines, device, user, timestamp, hashes and ReportId.

2

Collect scripts

Acquire the VBS and PS1 files and verify the exact _apex or _audit pairing.

3

Trace npm origin

Review package manager logs, lockfiles and package scope for @apexacc/cli or @apexacc/audit.

4

Scope follow-on

Review adjacent file, process, registry and network events without assuming later source-described stages ran.

Expected benign overlap

Development, packaging or security tests may use WScript to invoke PowerShell with execution-policy bypass. The paired campaign filenames substantially reduce, but do not eliminate, overlap.

Tuning

Allowlist only verified script hashes, repositories, package owners, signing chains or managed deployment records. Do not suppress WScript or PowerShell globally.

VALIDATION GATES

Controlled tests and promotion criteria.

QUALITY CONTROL

Validation steps

1. Confirm full child and initiating command-line collection.
2. Execute an authorized VBS-to-PowerShell reproduction using the exact published flags and filenames.
3. Measure 30 days of hits and identify legitimate script owners.
4. Verify raw events preserve the direct WScript parent and paired artifact names.

Decision criteria

Success: the controlled chain is visible and real matches retain collectible wrapper and package provenance.

Rejection: legitimate use creates inseparable overlap or the published artifacts are no longer reliable.

Failure: child or initiating command lines are missing or truncated.

Promotion gate

Remain a campaign hunt until telemetry coverage, prevalence, ownership and false-positive handling are demonstrated in the target environment.

CONCLUSION AND REFERENCES

Coverage statement, platform limits and document control.

FINAL

CONCLUSION

A direct execution hunt anchored to mutable campaign artifacts.

The parent-child behavior and flags are directly reported, and Defender fields are documented. Exact script names improve specificity but prevent durable production classification.

Cross-SIEM decision

Splunk: no reliable SPL without a verified endpoint source, index, sourcetype and exact child/parent command-line fields.

Chronicle: no reliable YARA-L without a verified endpoint parser and exact UDM mapping for created and parent process command lines.

Deferred ideas

Generic WScript-to-PowerShell alerts, encoded-command matching, Defender-exclusion changes, Smart App Control changes, domains and package-name-only rules.

References

1. Primary technical research — Elastic Security Labs, "Auditing the auditor: Unmasking Apex Accelerator", published 2026-10-12; observed activity period not disclosed; accessed 2026-10-14:
2. hxxps://www[.]elastic[.]co/security-labs/auditing-the-auditor-unmasking-apex-accelerator
3. Official schema documentation — Microsoft Learn, "DeviceProcessEvents table in the advanced hunting schema", updated 2026-08-07; accessed 2026-10-14:
4. hxxps://learn[.]microsoft[.]com/en-us/defender-xdr/advanced-hunting-deviceprocessevents-table
5. MITRE ATT&CK — T1059.001 PowerShell; accessed 2026-10-14:
6. hxxps://attack[.]mitre[.]org/techniques/T1059/001/
7. MITRE ATT&CK — T1059.005 Visual Basic; accessed 2026-10-14:
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Document control

Canonical locked typography and layout. Only the campaign illustration on page 1 is variable. No customer data. References defanged.